

Philosophical Foundations — Module 02: Agents —

Study Questions

1. What is a "self-model" in Active Inference? What aspects of selfhood does it capture?
2. Compare the FEP self-model with Hume's bundle theory. What are the similarities and differences?
3. How does Metzinger's "Being No One" relate to Active Inference's account of the self?
4. How does the Buddhist concept of anattā (no-self) map onto the continuously updated posterior?
5. State the hard problem of consciousness. What does Active Inference explain and what doesn't it?
6. What is phenomenal self-modeling? Can it address the hard problem?
7. Define agential minimalism. What are the minimal conditions for agency under the FEP?
8. Is a thermostat an agent? Defend both "yes" and "no" positions using the FEP framework.
9. How does the graduated ontology (physical system → simple agent → cognitive agent → self-conscious agent) avoid the trivializing objection?
10. What is the dark room objection to agency? How does Active Inference respond?
11. How does Active Inference handle the free will debate? Is it deterministic, compatibilist, or libertarian?
12. What is autonomy in the FEP sense? How is it measured formally?
13. How does Active Inference account for personal identity over time?
14. What role does narrative identity play in the generative model?
15. How does allostatic regulation provide a formal criterion for persistence?
16. Can Active Inference explain disorders of selfhood (depersonalization, dissociation)?
17. How does interoceptive inference relate to emotional experience?
18. Compare Active Inference's account of agency with Dennett's intentional stance.
19. Does Active Inference support functionalism about the mind? Why or why not?
20. Critically evaluate: Is the FEP's "self" genuinely explanatory, or just a redescription of what we already know about self-awareness?